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Date: 04/26/2026

Company: NYPD

Title: NYPD Domain Awareness System: The Promise of Smart Policing and the Price of Privacy

Link to Github: <https://github.com/Scarchichi/NYPD-DT-Project>

The case study sets the stage well, introducing the Police Commissioner Raymond W. Kelly as our main protagonist, who is dealing with the dynamic between privacy and security. The DT (Digital Transformation) initiative is the Domain Awareness System (DAS), which is a sensor-fusion platform developed in partnership with Microsoft and Patternizr to integrate 9,000 CCTV cameras to track patterns of crimes in New York City. Specifically, the DAS can read license plates, chemical sensors, gunshot detectors, and alert local authorities on mobile devices to report to the area where it was captured. DAS is strategically interesting because it helps aid local law enforcement in detective work. Instead of hours of viewing/interpreting CCTV footage or guessing where a crime happened, it is all pre-recorded and tracked appropriately. The DAS has fundamentally changed how policing is done. However, there are risks that the DAS comes with. The system was designed with aiding investigators in mind, but is seen as a surveillance overreach, one that can be utilized to prosecute protestors. These risks, as a former law enforcement professional, are tradeoffs to an overall solution to one of the nation's most populous metropolitan areas. The governance gap (written policy and independent law enforcement) and algorithmic bias in Patternizr (a tool that is only as unbiased as the historical policing data put into train it) compound the problem into what it is today. How the NYPD utilizes this data is completely up to who the chief is, who is the mayor, which squad responds to the alert, and what the priorities are of the administration (if political 'unrest' is seen as a weapon to society, law enforcement will respond as such).

The AI output tools (Claude, GitHub Copilot, and Perplexity) were all accurate on the core facts of DAS. Dates, partnerships, and policy impact were all correct. It was lacking names for specific law enforcement attaches who talk to the press, which I think would have added more to the story. Overall, there were no errors in factual information. What kept recurring during my development of the story arc was that it kept presenting key facts, main characters, and examples, but not a full-length feature story. I wanted something close to an episode of Law & Order, not a brief to a Unit Chief (which is basically a run-down of key facts).

The most concrete thing I learned working with AI (and a common trend in our class) is that AI tools excel at synthesis and structure, but require human direction on what matters the most in the story. When I first asked Claude to describe DAS and the story, the output was accurate, but it framed it as a technological overview. It listed the capacities without the main tension of the story, which is governance. I learned that vague prompts produce shallow outputs (garbage in, garbage out). So, each tool that I used played a distinct role. When I referred to Claude, it was best for finding source material. As a former international relations scholar, I didn't want Wikipedia sources. I wanted Open-Source materials like news, social media, and case studies. For Claude, it was best for developing the narrative I wanted and kind of brainstorming where I wanted the story to go. The reason I opted out of Perplexity was that I completely ran out of

credits on my student account, so I relied on the GitHub Copilot for the rest of the assignment. In the NYPD DT case, I learned that digital transformation can aid but also undermine the legitimacy on which an organization like the NYPD depends. On the federal level and local level, there is one truth we both share, which is that we depend on public trust to effectively do our jobs. The NYPD's relationship with local communities, especially highly-surveillance neighborhoods, requires a delicate balance of relationship-building to be effective. If the DAS erodes that trust, it degrades the quality of tip information, voluntary cooperation, and public support that leads to effective policing. The NYPD DAS case is unique in that it is effective and speedy, but at the cost of long-term distrust in the communities it is being implemented in. How the NYPD builds those relationships again is vital and crucial to the mission of the agency.

As previously mentioned, the tools used were Claude, Perplexity, and GitHub Copilot. The most effective prompting approach was the third time around, when I asked GitHub Copilot to emphasize the story. I also prompted 'use legitimate' sources rather than Wikipedia, since I knew I wanted something close to a Harvard Business Case. What I would do differently is front-load all source verification more aggressively. I spent more time caring about the narrative than worrying about citations, and only prompted it after the fact. I'd also utilize Perplexity's citation features more systematically from the start, building the source registry before actually drafting.